

The Toddler Sleep Fix: End the Bedtime Wars Without Crying It Out

Introduction: Why Bedtime Feels Like a Contact Sport

You know you should be asleep by now. They know it too. And somehow that makes it worse.

You've tried the routine. You've tried the patience. You've tried the "just a few more minutes" negotiation, the sticker charts, the stories, the white noise, the blackout curtains. And still—every single night—your toddler turns bedtime into a contact sport.

Maybe you've Googled "toddler sleep regression" at 11pm more times than you'd like to admit. Maybe you've read threads where parents brag about their kids sleeping 12 hours straight and wondered what parallel universe they live in. Maybe you've quietly wondered if something is genuinely wrong with your child, or worse, with you.

Here's what you don't hear enough: **this is not a parenting failure**. This is a toddler brain doing exactly what toddler brains are wired to do at this exact developmental stage. The separation anxiety, the object permanence returning with a vengeance, the imagination that's suddenly vivid enough to conjure monsters—these aren't bugs in your child's system. They're features.

And here's the thing: the standard sleep advice—the sleep training methods that worked for your friend's baby, the "they'll figure it out eventually" reassurance—was never designed for what's actually happening in that head of yours right now.

This guide changes that.

Over the next sections, you'll get a concrete, sequence-by-sequence playbook for transforming bedtime from a daily war into something your family can actually sustain. Not a miracle cure. Not a promise of perfect nights. But a real, repeatable system that works *with* your toddler's development instead of against it.

You will learn to read the signals before they escalate, respond without giving in or losing your cool, and build a wind-down architecture that actually signals "it's time to sleep" to a brain that's wired to resist it.

You deserve to close the door at 8pm and have it stay closed. Let's build that.

PART 1: THE RECALIBRATION

Why bedtime feels impossible and what your toddler actually needs

Chapter 1: Decode the "Why Now"

Before you can fix the problem, you need to understand it. Not in abstract terms, but in the specific, observable reality of what's happening in your child's brain during the 18-month to 3-year window.

The Separation Anxiety You Thought You Passed

Here's something most sleep guides skip: separation anxiety isn't a one-time event. It peaks around 8-10 months, and then it comes back with a vengeance between 18 months and 3 years—not because your child regressed, but because their *understanding* of separation has evolved.

Your toddler now has a more sophisticated grasp of object permanence. They know you're a separate person who exists even when they can't see you. And that knowledge cuts both ways: they know you can leave, and they know you might not come back.

This is why the old "just put them down and walk away" advice often fails spectacularly at this age. Your toddler isn't being difficult. They're experiencing genuine, developmentally normal anxiety that they lack the words to express.

The Imagination Problem

Between 18 months and 3 years, your child's imagination is exploding. They can now conjure scenarios, remember things that happened earlier in the day, and—in a development that's genuinely exciting in daylight hours—create fears that feel completely real in the dark.

That shadow on the wall? A monster. The creak in the floorboard? A intruder. The dark itself? A thing with weight and presence.

This isn't weakness or irrationality. It's a sign of normal cognitive development happening on schedule. But it means that bedtime resistance that looks like "stalling" might actually be fear—a real, legitimate fear your child doesn't know how to handle.

The Autonomy Push

Here's the other piece: around age 2, your toddler is discovering that they have preferences, opinions, and power. They want to say no. They want to choose. They want to test boundaries.

Bedtime is a perfect stage for this push because it's one of the few domains where they've historically had less control. So they push back—not because they're being manipulative, but because they're testing their own agency and learning where their power lies.

The Sleep Root Cause Checklist

Not all bedtime resistance has the same root. Before you can fix it, you need to know what you're actually dealing with. Here's a quick diagnostic:

- **Won't stay in bed:** Likely separation anxiety or fear-based. They're okay when you're there, panicking when you leave.
- **Stalling tactics:** Likely autonomy-seeking or avoidance of something they find aversive (sleep itself, or the transition from preferred activity). Look for patterns: same requests every night, escalation timing, what happens if you say yes vs. no.
- **Fear-based resistance:** They might say "I don't want to sleep" or "I'm scared" or refuse to close eyes. Often tied to imagination development or previous scary experiences (a fall, a nightmare, even a loud noise they processed later).
- **Control-seeking:** The negotiation, the "one more thing," the power struggle. This is your toddler practicing their new sense of agency.

Action Step: For the next three nights, keep a simple log. Before bed, note what happened in the last hour (roughhousing? screen time? a frustrating day?). After bedtime, note what specific behaviors came up (crying? demands? resistance to routine steps?). After a few nights, you'll likely see a pattern emerge.

Key Takeaway: Toddler bedtime resistance has specific developmental roots—separation anxiety, imagination-driven fear, and autonomy-seeking. Identifying which pattern fits your child is the first step to addressing it.

Chapter 2: Why Standard Sleep Training Fails at This Age

You might have tried a version of cry-it-out with your first child. Or read about extinction-based methods and wondered if you should try them now. Here's why those approaches often backfire in the toddler window—and what happens when they do.

What Cry-It-Out Actually Does

The cry-it-out method (also called extinction) works on a principle of graduated exposure: your child cries, you wait longer and longer intervals, eventually they learn that crying doesn't bring you and they stop. It's effective for some infants, especially around the 4-6 month mark when sleep consolidation is a developmental milestone rather than an emotional negotiation.

But your toddler is not the same as an infant. They have:

- **Emotional memory:** They remember what happened last night, and the night before. If crying until you came resulted in you leaving after 5 minutes, they'll cry for 6 minutes next time expecting you to come at 7. The cycle escalates.
- **Metacognition:** Toddlers are starting to think about their own thinking. They can anticipate outcomes and strategize. When they cry and you don't come, they experience something more complicated than "learned helplessness"—they experience *relational uncertainty*. "Does Mom come back? Sometimes? Under what conditions?"
- **Language, even limited:** Your toddler can understand more than they can say. They know when you're frustrated. They can pick up on the emotional temperature of the room even if they can't articulate it.

What Actually Happens

When parents try cry-it-out with a toddler who has separation anxiety, one of two things usually happens:

1. The crying escalates. It goes from sad to panicked. The child isn't learning that you'll come— they're learning that when they're most scared, you're not there.
2. The child shuts down. They stop crying, but not because they've self-soothed. They've learned that crying doesn't work, and they've disconnected as a coping mechanism. This might look "successful" on a sleep training timeline. But it often comes with a cost: increased separation anxiety, clinginess during the day, and a muted emotional responsiveness that many parents report.

Neither outcome is what you signed up for.

The 3-Point Framework for Why Toddler Sleep Requires a Different Approach

1. **Relationship is the context.** Your toddler's sleep doesn't happen in isolation from your relationship with them. Every bedtime interaction is either building or

eroding trust. Sleep training methods that treat sleep as a mechanical problem to be solved ignore the relational context that makes sustainable sleep possible.

2. **Regulation is developmental.** Toddlers don't have the same capacity for self-regulation that older children or adults do. They can't "calm down" on command. Their nervous systems need co-regulation—your calm presence—to transition into sleep. This is why presence-based approaches work better than absence-based ones at this age.
3. **Fear doesn't respond to logic.** You can't explain to a 2-year-old that monsters aren't real and they'll nod off peacefully. You also can't teach them that you're "right there" if they just believe hard enough. Fear needs to be met with presence, not reasoning. This is a key distinction from how we address fear in older children.

Action Step: If you've tried extinction-based methods and found them distressing—for your child or for you—drop the guilt. You were following advice that was designed for a different developmental window. What happened wasn't your failure; it was a mismatch between method and moment. This is reversible.

Key Takeaway: Standard cry-it-out methods often backfire with toddlers because toddlers have emotional memory, relational awareness, and limited self-regulation capacity. A different approach—one that works with development instead of against it—is needed.

Chapter 3: Shift Your Mental Model

Here's the mindset shift that will change everything: stop thinking about bedtime as "getting your child to sleep." Start thinking about it as building a neurological wind-down sequence.

Why "Go to Sleep" Is the Wrong Goal

When bedtime is about making your child fall asleep, you're in an adversarial position. Your child has all the power—they're the one who decides whether their eyes close, and every demand or resistance they make is a signal that the goal isn't achieved yet.

But sleep isn't a thing you can force. It's a neurological state that emerges when the conditions are right. Your job isn't to push your child into sleep. Your job is to create those conditions.

The Wind-Down Sequence

Think about your own sleep transition. You probably don't go from full wakefulness to unconscious in five minutes. There's a sequence: the lights dim, the screens go away, the body settles, the mind quiets. This process takes time and involves specific neurological signals.

Your toddler needs the same thing—a sequence, not a switch.

The wind-down sequence has four stages:

1. **Alertness reduction:** This starts 30-60 minutes before bed. Screen time ends, physical play stops, the activity level drops. Your child's body starts to register that the day is winding down.
2. **Environmental signal:** The room changes. Lights dim. The temperature shifts slightly. A white noise machine turns on. The brain starts to associate these cues with sleep time.
3. **Routine completion:** A consistent sequence of events (bath, pajama, teeth, story, song, bed) that your child can predict. Prediction reduces anxiety. Structure creates safety.
4. **Safe transition:** The moment when you leave. For a toddler with separation anxiety, this is the hardest part. The goal isn't to make it painless—it's to make it predictable, brief, and trust-building.

The Nightly Energy Audit

Here's a practical tool you can use starting tonight. Before you begin your bedtime routine, take two minutes to assess:

- What happened in the last 2-3 hours? (High-energy play? Screens? A nap that was too late? A missed meal or snack?)
- What's your child's current state? (Giddy? Cranky? Over-tired? Calm?)
- What are you bringing to this interaction? (Calm? Frustrated? Rushed?)

The quality of your wind-down sequence depends on all three inputs. If your child is over-tired, you might need to adjust timing. If you're bringing tension, you might need to take three deep breaths before you start. If there was a big disruption earlier (screens, lots of sugar, a frustrating experience), you might need extra buffer time.

Action Step: Tomorrow, before bed, complete the Nightly Energy Audit. Write down or mentally note the three inputs: what happened earlier, your child's current state, and

your own state. Then adjust your wind-down accordingly. If you're rushed and frustrated, slow down. If your child is wired, extend the pre-bed wind-down.

Key Takeaway: Reframe bedtime as building a wind-down sequence rather than forcing sleep. When you create the right conditions—reduced stimulation, consistent routine, safe transition—sleep becomes possible rather than obligatory.

PART 2: THE FOUNDATION

Building the architecture that makes sleep inevitable

Chapter 4: Build Your Wind-Down Sequence

The wind-down sequence isn't just a routine. It's a neurological program you're installing in your child's brain. The more consistent it is, the more automatic it becomes—both for them and for you.

The Components of a Strong Sequence

A good toddler bedtime sequence has five to seven steps, and each step should be in the same order every time. Research on habit formation suggests that context cues are powerful: when your child sees the first step, their brain anticipates the rest.

Here's a sample sequence:

1. **Wind-down signal:** A specific phrase or ritual that marks the transition. "The house is getting quiet. It's almost bedtime." Or turning on a specific lamp. This gives your child a heads-up that change is coming.
2. **Calm activity:** Something that lowers arousal without being screen-based. Coloring, reading together, puzzles, water play. Duration: 15-20 minutes.
3. **Bath (optional):** A warm bath can be genuinely calming for many toddlers. Not necessary every night, but useful when your child is particularly wired.
4. **Pajamas and teeth:** Transitional from dress-up to sleep-mode.
5. **Two to three books:** Enough to feel satisfying, not so many that it becomes a bargaining chip.
6. **Lullaby or quiet song:** A consistent audio signal that sleep is coming.

7. **The goodnight ritual:** A specific, repeatable sequence. Something like:
"Goodnight to your toes, goodnight to your nose, goodnight to the moon up above, goodnight to the room, goodnight to you, and I love you." Fill in your own version.

The "Last Thing" Trap

One of the most common stall tactics toddlers use is "one more thing." They want water, another story, to show you something, to go to the bathroom six times. Each request feels small, but the pattern can stretch bedtime indefinitely.

The solution isn't to deny these requests categorically—sometimes they're legitimate. But you need a framework for handling them.

The Buffer Strategy: Build in a "last chance" moment at the end of the routine, before you do the final goodnight. "This is the last book. After this, it's time to sleep. Do you need to use the potty? Get your lovey? Have a sip of water?" Give them the chance to name their final need, address it once, and then close the loop.

The "Same Answer, Different Time" Rule: Whatever you say at the beginning of the routine ("Okay, two books tonight") stays consistent even when they ask for three. "We already read our books. It's time to sleep now." No new negotiations after the routine has started.

Action Step: Map out your current bedtime routine, or create a new one from scratch if you don't have a consistent one. Write down each step and the approximate time it takes. Aim for 30-45 minutes total. Test it for three nights and note what works and what creates friction.

Key Takeaway: A consistent wind-down sequence acts as a neurological cue for sleep. Build five to seven repeatable steps, include a "last chance" buffer to reduce stalling, and stick to your boundaries once the routine begins.

Chapter 5: The Room Environment Toolkit

Your toddler's sleep environment matters more than you might think. At this age, they have enough cognitive sophistication to be affected by environmental details, but not enough rational thinking to dismiss them.

Light

Toddlers who are afraid of the dark often have a harder time settling than those who aren't—because darkness triggers their imagination to fill in scary details.

The solution isn't necessarily a bright nightlight (which can interfere with melatonin production). Instead, try a **dim red or orange light** that provides enough visibility to reduce fear but doesn't signal "daytime" to the brain. Some parents use a small lamp on the far side of the room, or a salt lamp. Others use a small LED that projects a calm pattern.

If your child is afraid of specific things (monsters under the bed), the light solution might need to be paired with a brief, matter-of-fact "check" ritual. "Let's check under the bed together to make sure there's no one there." You check once, they're satisfied, and then the light helps maintain the calm.

Sound

White noise machines serve two purposes: they mask sudden sounds that might startle a half-asleep child, and they provide a consistent audio environment that signals "sleep mode."

Use a consistent volume and keep the machine on all night. The sound becomes part of the sleep context, and when your child wakes in the night, the white noise is there to ease them back.

Temperature

Toddlers sleep better in slightly cooler rooms—around 68-72°F (20-22°C). Overheating is disruptive to sleep, and many parents overbundle their children without realizing it.

A quick check: if you can hear your child's breathing through the monitor, they're probably at a good temperature. If they're sweating or seem uncomfortable, adjust the thermostat or the pajamas.

Safety Objects

If your child has a lovey, stuffed animal, or special blanket, this is the time to have it available. A safety object provides a tangible link to comfort when you're not in the room. It won't solve separation anxiety on its own, but it can be a bridge that helps.

If your child doesn't have a designated comfort object, this is a good time to introduce one during the daytime—make it part of play, keep it nearby, and let it gradually become associated with comfort.

Action Step: Spend 15 minutes adjusting your child's room environment. Add or adjust a light source, set up a white noise machine (or a fan, if you don't have one), check the temperature. Note any changes in how quickly your child settles over the next week.

Key Takeaway: Environmental factors—light, sound, temperature, and comfort objects—significantly impact toddler sleep quality. Small adjustments to the room can reduce anxiety, mask disruptive sounds, and create a consistent sleep context.

PART 3: THE RESPONSE PROTOCOL

What to do when the resistance hits

Chapter 6: The STAY Method for Bedtime Resistance

Here's the thing about toddler bedtime resistance: it will happen. Even with a perfect wind-down sequence and an ideal environment, your child will occasionally fight sleep. That's not a failure of your system—it's just toddlers being toddlers.

The question is how you respond in the moment. That's where the STAY Method comes in.

S — Slow Your Roll

When your child escalates, your nervous system wants to match theirs. Don't let it. Take one deliberate breath before you respond. This isn't about suppressing your feelings—it's about becoming an island of calm in their storm.

Toddlers are exquisitely attuned to the emotional state of their caregivers. When you stay calm, you signal safety. When you escalate, you confirm that something scary is happening.

T — Tune Into the Need

What's actually happening here? Before you respond to the behavior (the crying, the stalling, the demands), ask yourself what feeling or need it represents.

- Crying that intensifies when you try to leave: **separation anxiety** → need is for your presence
- Repetitive demands for water or one more story: **control-seeking** → need is for some sense of agency
- Fearful statements, anxiety about the dark: **imagination-driven fear** → need is for reassurance
- Combative, physical resistance: **over-tiredness** → need is for more co-regulation

The behavior is a message. Your job is to decode it without trying to solve it in the moment.

A — Acknowledge and Set

Acknowledge the feeling without arguing with it. "I can see you really want to stay up. It feels hard to end the day." But then **set the boundary**. "But it's bedtime. I'm going to close the door now."

This is the part that most parents struggle with. They want to negotiate, or to explain, or to reason their way to compliance. Don't. Your child already knows it's bedtime. The negotiation is a test, not a genuine inquiry.

One clear statement. Then follow through.

Y — Yield Nothing, Except Calm

Here's the paradox: the more you argue, negotiate, or escalate, the more your child learns that escalation works. The more you stay calm and consistent, the more they learn that bedtime is bedtime and the outcome is the same.

This doesn't mean being cold. You can be warm, present, and affectionate while also being completely clear. "I love you. I'm right here. And it's still time to sleep."

One caveat: if your child is genuinely panicking—crying hard, showing signs of true fear—then staying in the room a little longer and providing extra co-regulation may be appropriate. But this should be the exception, not the rule, and it should always end with departure.

The Leave Timer

One useful technique for managing the exit: set a timer on your phone for however long you've decided to stay (2-3 minutes is often enough). Tell your child: "I'm going to sit here for two minutes, and then I'm going to close the door and it's time to sleep." When the timer goes off, you leave.

Don't sneak out. Don't wait for them to stop crying. Leave while the timer signals it's time. This builds predictability and trust.

Action Step: Tonight, when your child resists bedtime, use the STAY Method. Slow your breath first. Identify the underlying need. Make one clear statement acknowledging the feeling and setting the boundary. Then leave at your planned time.

Key Takeaway: The STAY Method (Slow, Tune Into the Need, Acknowledge and Set, Yield Nothing Except Calm) gives you a consistent framework for handling bedtime resistance without escalating or giving in. Your calm presence is the bridge to their ability to settle.

Chapter 7: Managing Night Wakings

For many parents of toddlers, the bedtime battle is only half the problem. The other half is the wake-up calls—the 1am visits, the 3am negotiations, the 5am "I'm up for the day" declarations.

Here's the honest truth: some night waking is normal for toddlers. They're not machines. They have sleep cycles, and they sometimes need help getting back to sleep between them. But there are patterns that can be addressed, and patterns that are habits that were inadvertently installed.

What's Normal

Waking once or twice per night, calling out, needing some help to resettle—these are within normal range for toddlers. If it happens infrequently and they're easy to settle back, this may just be a phase that passes.

What's a Habit

If your child consistently wakes at the same time (like 2am like clockwork), demands something specific (a bottle, a song, your presence for 30 minutes), and seems very alert rather than groggy, that's a learned pattern. They woke up, got something, and now the wake-up has become the cue for the reward.

Breaking the Wake-Up Reward Cycle

The goal isn't to ignore your child—it's to change the equation. When they wake, your response should be brief, boring, and consistent.

- **Keep the lights off.** If you turn on lights, play, or give extended attention, you signal "wake up time." A dim nightlight and a minimal voice are enough.
- **Keep your response the same.** If you've established that you come in, check on them, and leave, then your response should look the same every time. "You're safe. It's still night. Time to sleep." Short. No negotiation.
- **Stay a short time.** If you're still doing presence-based settling, keep it brief—2-5 minutes max. Then leave.
- **Expect a rough night or two.** When you change the pattern, your child will test it. Expect some pushback, and stay consistent.

The 5am Wake-Up Problem

This one is notoriously hard. A toddler who wakes at 5am and refuses to go back to sleep has usually had enough sleep. The solution is either to push bedtime later (if they went to bed very early) or to accept this as their natural wake time and adjust the morning routine accordingly.

If you want to try shifting it, move bedtime 15 minutes later every few days until you find a sustainable time. But be prepared: this might just be your child's biology, at least for now.

Action Step: For the next five nights, log any night wakings. Note the time, what you did, and how long it took to settle your child. Look for patterns and consider whether any of those patterns are habits that could be changed with more consistent responses.

Key Takeaway: Some night waking is normal for toddlers, but consistent wake-ups at specific times may indicate learned habits. Brief, boring, consistent responses can help break the wake-up reward cycle over time.

PART 4: THE SYSTEM

Putting it together and sustaining progress

Chapter 8: Troubleshooting Common Patterns

Every toddler is different, and your specific situation will have quirks that require adaptation. Here are some common patterns and how to approach them.

Pattern: The Split-Night

Your child goes to sleep fine but wakes up for 1-2 hours in the middle of the night, wide awake. This often happens when bedtime is too early (your child hasn't accumulated enough sleep pressure yet) or when there was a long daytime gap.

Fix: Try moving bedtime 15-30 minutes later for a week and see if the middle-of-the-night wake-up resolves.

Pattern: The Early Riser

Your child consistently wakes at 5am or earlier and won't go back to sleep, regardless of bedtime timing.

Fix: This is often a hard-wired pattern. Some options: black-out shades to block the early light (which signals "wake up" even at 5am), a very consistent morning routine

that starts the day in a low-key way (no screens, dim lights for the first 30 minutes), and acceptance that this may be a phase that eventually resolves.

Pattern: The Regression After Travel or Disruption

Your child was sleeping well, then you traveled or had a major disruption, and now the problems are back.

Fix: This is incredibly common. Your child experienced a change, and their sleep boundaries have been tested. Go back to basics: rebuild the routine consistency, expect a rough few nights, don't over-correct or add too many new sleep associations. The regression usually resolves in 1-2 weeks with consistent response.

Pattern: The Sibling Disruption

You have another child who shares the room, and they're waking each other up.

Fix: If possible, separate them for sleep (different rooms, or one sleeps in a travel situation temporarily). If that's not feasible, focus on making each child's sleep environment as robust as possible against noise—white noise, blackout conditions, visual barriers.

The Progress Trap

One thing to watch out for: when your child starts sleeping better, it's tempting to relax the routine. Don't.

The routine is doing the work. If you start skipping steps, changing the order, or letting bedtime drift later, you'll likely see regression. The good news: when things are working, it means the system is sound. Tweak gently, not wholesale.

Action Step: Identify which pattern matches your situation best. Implement the suggested fix for one week and note whether there's improvement. If not, try the next approach.

Key Takeaway: Common patterns like split nights, early waking, regressions, and sibling disruption all have specific approaches. The key is to observe, adjust one variable at a time, and stay consistent.

Conclusion: What You've Built

If you've made it here, you now have something more valuable than a list of tips. You have a framework—a way of understanding what's actually happening when your toddler fights bedtime, and a system for addressing it.

Let's recap what we've covered:

1. **Toddler bedtime resistance has specific developmental roots:** separation anxiety, imagination-driven fear, and autonomy-seeking. Your child isn't being difficult; they're being a normal toddler.
2. **Standard sleep training methods often fail at this age** because they ignore the relational and developmental realities of the toddler brain.
3. **Reframe bedtime as a wind-down sequence** rather than a battle to be won. When you create the right conditions—reduced stimulation, consistent routine, safe transition—sleep becomes possible.
4. **Build a consistent wind-down sequence** with five to seven repeatable steps, and use the buffer strategy to reduce stalling.
5. **Adjust the sleep environment** (light, sound, temperature, comfort objects) to reduce anxiety and create a consistent sleep context.
6. **Use the STAY Method** (Slow, Tune Into the Need, Acknowledge and Set, Yield Nothing Except Calm) for handling bedtime resistance in the moment.
7. **Address night wakings and common patterns** with brief, consistent responses and targeted troubleshooting.

Here's the truth: this won't be perfectly linear. Some nights will be hard. Some weeks will feel like two steps forward, one step back. You will have nights where you doubt whether any of this works.

It does work. But it works in the context of relationship, consistency, and patience with your own imperfect humanness.

Your Next Step

This guide gives you the understanding and the framework. But there's a companion piece that gives you the action tools: the **Toddler Sleep Fix Action Checklist**.

The checklist distills everything in this guide into a step-by-step reference you can keep on your nightstand. It includes the Sleep Root Cause Checklist, the Nightly Energy Audit template, the complete wind-down sequence builder, the STAY Method script, and the Troubleshooting Quick-Reference.

When you're tired and it's 8pm and your child is crying, you don't want to scroll through a guide. You want a checklist. That's what we've made for you.

Go there. Use it. And close the door.

Key Takeaways:

- Toddler bedtime resistance has developmental roots. Your child isn't failing—you're working with a brain that's doing exactly what it's supposed to do at this stage.
 - Standard sleep training often fails at this age. A relationship-based, development-aligned approach works better.
 - Reframe bedtime as a wind-down sequence, not a battle. Create the conditions for sleep, and sleep becomes possible.
 - Use the STAY Method in the moment: Slow, Tune Into the Need, Acknowledge and Set, Yield Nothing Except Calm.
 - Consistency is everything. The routine is doing the work. Protect it.
 - The companion Action Checklist is your next step—it's the practical tool for applying everything you've learned, night by night.
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You can do this. Not perfectly, but consistently. And consistency is what your child needs from you. Not perfection—just you, showing up the same way, night after night, until they believe that bedtime is safe.